I reached that second milestone with a crudded single. ‘I didn’t know that,’ I mentioned to Rooty, when the screens announced the news. ‘You’re a fucking liar,’ he laughed, reading my smile. I knew the century was on; when it arrived, at 12.43 on Monday, 10 September 2018, it was a mixture of high drama and low comedy.

I took an easy single to deep gully on 96, thought, ‘That’s one closer,’ and then saw Jasprit Bumrah launch the return, harder than he’d ever thrown it. ‘Run, run, run,’ screamed Rooty. I followed the ball out of the corner of my eye as it sped towards Cheteshwar Pujara who, thankfully, isn’t the quickest fielder on the deep point boundary.

I started laughing when I realized he was never going to get it. The ball ended in the groundsman’s hut, a suitably surreal footnote to a moment that meant so much. It would have been nice to get there with a poetic flourish, or a favourite shot, but to be brutally honest I’ll take it. Mo might just have been right. It was written.

The ovation was amazing, rolling around the place like thunder. It just kept on going. Rooty hugged me hard and didn’t need to say a word. I raised my bat towards the boys behind the glass on the dressing-room balcony and saw movement that, on closer inspection of TV replays two days later, involved Jimmy pogoing up and down like a five-year-old.

Thank God I didn’t cry. I came close, exhaled deeply and regularly, tried and failed to keep things in the present tense. I went back down the wicket, urged Joe to ‘watch the ball’, but the words had little immediate meaning. They couldn’t reflect the purity of my happiness. I found myself looking at the crowd and thinking, ‘Boy, they must be having a good time.’

I knew Mum would be somewhere, in tears. I thought of Alice’s sacrifices, in putting her life on hold for my cricket, and hoped the girls would remember the moment. Jack, our son, was due to be born the following day, but hung around for a couple of weeks before making an appearance.

By that time I had learned that Gemma Broad, Stuart’s sister, had sat for half an hour in a B&Q car park, listening to the radio in anticipation of me reaching a century she was determined not to miss. When I did so she leapt up and screamed; suddenly self-conscious, she looked at the adjoining car, where the driver was also in tears.

Sport has that effect on people. Strangers share your life without you knowing. It is an emotional, communal experience. I probably walked off